

Eclipses

Eclipses were very important in the early period of astrology. One of the main tasks of Chinese and Mesopotamian astrologers was predicting eclipses. In contemporary astrology, eclipses are not part of the astrologer's standard toolkit, but they are indeed still used.

Types of eclipses

We know eclipses as solar eclipses and lunar eclipses. There are also further subdivisions of eclipses.

TYPE	DESCRIPTION
Total	In a solar eclipse: the Moon completely covers the Sun. In a lunar eclipse: the Moon is entirely within the Earth's umbra (core shadow).
Partial	In a solar eclipse: the Moon covers only part of the Sun. In a lunar eclipse: the Moon is partly within the Earth's umbra (core shadow).
Annular	Only in solar eclipses. The Moon is far from the Earth, close to its apogee, and appears optically smaller. It stands entirely in front of the Sun, but a ring of sunlight remains visible around the Moon.
Hybrid	Only in solar eclipses. A fairly rare combination: in some places an annular eclipse is visible, while in others a total eclipse is seen. This can happen when the Moon appears optically almost the same size as the Sun.
Penumbral	Only in lunar eclipses. The Moon is not in the umbra (core shadow) but entirely within the penumbra (partial shadow). This is a subtle eclipse that is difficult to recognize as such.

Interpretation

In Babylonian astrology, the last eclipse before a birth played a major role. You can determine that eclipse's position in the horoscope, but you can also cast a horoscope for the moment of the eclipse itself.

The Saros cycle

Eclipses occur in predictable cycles. The best-known cycle is the Saros cycle. Within this cycle, eclipses recur many times at intervals of 18 years, 11 days, and 8 hours. Such a cycle begins at one of the poles as a small partial eclipse and repeats itself roughly 40 times over a period of 12 to 13 centuries. There are multiple Saros cycles that overlap each other in time. Such a cycle is identified by a number, along with a sequence number for the eclipse within that cycle.

Bernadette Brady attaches significance to the first eclipse within a Saros cycle.



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